

Initial Briefing: Case #VAN-2025-010 - Pharmaceutical Lab Intrusions

Case ID: VAN-2025-010

Date Reported: 2025-04-15 (Compiled from multiple initial reports starting late March 2025)

Location(s): Multiple secure pharmaceutical research facilities across Metro Vancouver (including sites at UBC and Burnaby).

Crime Type: Suspected Corporate Espionage / Intellectual Property Theft / Unauthorized Computer Access.

Initial Situation:

Several pharmaceutical research labs have independently reported anomalies and suspected unauthorized access to their computer systems over the past 2-3 weeks. There appears to be a pattern emerging.

Key Initial Findings:

1. **Suspicious Access Events:** In each reported incident, access appears to have been gained by an individual impersonating a legitimate visitor (e.g., visiting researcher, regulatory inspector, equipment technician). Different aliases and high-quality forged credentials were used at each location.
2. **Social Engineering:** The individual demonstrated familiarity with general lab protocols and terminology, allowing them to navigate semi-secure areas without immediate suspicion. Staff interviews indicate the person was persuasive and confident.
3. **Workstation Compromise:** Following these visits, IT departments discovered unauthorized software (initially flagged as sophisticated spyware/malware) installed on specific research workstations. These workstations were often located in adjacent offices or common areas, not necessarily within the highest-security lab spaces themselves. Access logs show logins to these workstations during or shortly after the suspicious individual's presence in the vicinity.
4. **Data Exfiltration:** Network traffic analysis reveals slow, encrypted outbound data transfers from the compromised workstations to multiple, seemingly unrelated IP addresses hosted in foreign countries known for data privacy havens. The exfiltration appears designed to mimic legitimate background traffic.
5. **Targeted Data:** Preliminary analysis of the spyware suggests it targets specific file types and keywords associated with proprietary research data, chemical formulas, and clinical trial results.
6. **Minimal Physical Evidence:** No signs of forced physical entry. The perpetrator seems to have relied on impersonation and exploiting opportunities (e.g., unattended workstations, found keycards). Minimal forensic evidence has been

recovered from the physical locations so far.

7. **No Material Theft:** Unlike typical burglaries, no physical equipment, materials, or documents appear to have been stolen. The objective seems purely data-focused.

Current Status:

The investigation is in its early stages. Forensics teams are analyzing the recovered spyware and network logs from multiple sites. Investigators are compiling witness descriptions of the impersonator(s) and reviewing CCTV footage from all affected facilities. The primary objectives are to identify the full scope of the compromise, understand the malware's capabilities, trace the data exfiltration path, and identify the perpetrator(s).